

ZHIYUAN LAI

Ph.D. Applicant (Fall 2027) | Peking University

Research interests: information practices, social justice, digital inequality, and human-centered AI

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EDUCATION

Peking University, Beijing, China

B.Mgt. in Information Management and Information Systems

Sep 2023 – Jun 2027 (expected)

B.A. in Sociology (Double Major)

Sep 2025 – Jun 2027 (expected)

GPA: 3.72/4.00; Rank: 7/82

National Tsing Hua University, Taiwan | Visiting Student

Jul 2025 – Aug 2025

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-reviewed publications

Lai, Z., Liang, X., Jiang, C., & Li, Z. Lives of the infamous: Identity linkage potential and everyday information practices among people living with HIV. *ACM/IEEE-CS Joint Conference on Digital Libraries (JCDL) 2026*, Accepted.

Lai, Z., & Tang, Y. (2026). Beyond or within the binary? Constructing gendered meanings in generative AI use. *Information Research: An International Electronic Journal*, 31(iConf), 328-344.
<https://doi.org/10.47989/ir31iConf64121>.

Chen, N., **Lai, Z.**, Liu, Y., Li, J., Wang, R., & Yan, P. (2026). See, trust, and interact: How AI disclosure shapes high school students' trust. *Information Research: An International Electronic Journal*, 31(iConf), 1099-1145.
<https://doi.org/10.47989/ir31iConf64165>.

Working Papers

Tang, Y., & **Lai, Z.** Empowering LGBTQIA+ identity formation in China through LLM-based chatbots. *Journal of Information Science*, Under Review.

Lai, Z., Ran, W., Chen, Z., & Yan, P. Public trust in generative AI in China: A mixed-methods scale development and validation study. Manuscript in preparation for submission to *Telematics & Informatics*.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE & SELECTED PROJECTS

33rd Peking University “Challenge Cup” Academic Competition (First Prize) Nov 2024 – Mar 2025

Rural Windows on Screens: Self-Presentation and Social Interaction of Middle-Aged and Elderly Women on Short-Video Platforms Advisor: Dr. Xingkun Liang

- Integrated ethnographic fieldwork in Langfang, Hebei (semi-structured interviews with 20 participants) and computational analysis from Douyin and Kuaishou (BERTopic for 19,193 public comments) to demonstrate how short-video practices enable middle-aged and older rural women to negotiate social marginalization, construct online identities, and sustain community ties.

34th Peking University “Challenge Cup” Academic Competition (Third Prize) Nov 2025 – Mar 2026

Lives Under Stigma: Biographical Disruption, Continuation, and Reconstruction among People Living with HIV — Information Practices as a Survival Strategy Advisor: Dr. Xingkun Liang

- Developed an inductive analytical framework based on multi-site fieldwork at Beijing Ditan Hospital and the Beijing Red Ribbon Home (22 semi-structured interviews, 32 hours of field observation, 2 months of online ethnography on RedNote), showing how people living with HIV regulate information disclosure, navigate identity-linking information flows, and convert information into sustainable everyday practices under conditions of stigma.

Undergraduate Research Program, Leader (Selected as Excellent Project) May 2024 – Oct 2025

Public Trust and Attitudes toward Generative AI in China Advisor: Dr. Pu Yan

(Selected as an Excellent Undergraduate Research Project)

- Led a multi-stage mixed-methods study, including developing an original scale of Trust in GenAI, validating the scale across two survey studies (N = 455 and 479) and designing a between-subject eye-tracking experiment (N=60) to examine how different AI disclosure strategies influence users' trust across different platform contexts.

Research Assistant, National Natural Science Foundation of China (Young Scientists Fund) May 2024–Present

A Study on the Influencing Factors and Mechanisms of the Algorithmic Divide. PI: Dr. Pu Yan

- Conducted literature reviews on the algorithmic divide and digital inequality, and analyzed survey data from 662 respondents using regression analysis with R to examine factors associated with algorithmic awareness, digital access, and social media use.

Research Assistant, Beijing Social Science Fund (General Project) May 2024–Present

A Study on Algorithm Literacy among Beijing Citizens PI: Dr. Pu Yan

- Refine and pilot-test survey instruments for measuring algorithm literacy across demographic groups. Designed and conducted an eye-tracking experiment in Beijing to examine users' visual attention and behavioral responses to algorithmically curated content on social media platforms.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

iConference 2026 Edinburgh, Scotland, UK | Mar 2026

Full Paper Presentation: "Beyond or within the binary? Constructing gendered meanings in generative AI use."

Annual Meeting of the Chinese Sociological Association 2026 Xi'an, China | Jul 2026

Poster Presentation: "Lives Under Stigma: Biographical Disruption, Continuation, and Reconstruction among People Living with HIV."

19th National Doctoral Forum in Library and Information Science Beijing, China | May 2026

Research Presentation: "The Lives of the Infamous: Information Practices as a Survival Strategy for People with HIV."

Annual Meeting of the Chinese Sociological Association 2025 Chengdu, China | Jul 2025

Full Paper Presentation: "Rural Windows on Screens: Self-Presentation and Social Interaction of Middle-Aged and Elderly Women on Short-Video Platforms."

HONORS & AWARDS

Third Prize, 34th Peking University "Challenge Cup" Academic Competition (Department-Level) 2026

First Prize, 33rd Peking University "Challenge Cup" Academic Competition (University-Level) 2025

Excellent Undergraduate Research Project, Peking University Undergraduate Research Program 2025

Merit Student; National Encouragement Scholarship; Second-Class Scholarship 2024–2025

Award for Academic Excellence; National Encouragement Scholarship 2023–2024

METHODOLOGICAL EXPERTISE

Qualitative Research Semi-structured interviews, participant observation, online ethnography

Survey Research Survey design, scale development and validation, psychometric analysis

Experimental Research Experimental design, eye tracking, behavioral data analysis

Computational Social Science Web scraping, topic modeling, text analysis

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Data Analytics & Programming Python, R, Stata, SPSS, NVivo, SQL

Web Technologies JavaScript, HTML, CSS

Languages English (TOEFL iBT: 104), Chinese (native), Hakka (native)